# What The Assignment Is Asking

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## What the Assignment is Asking

You will be doing Component 5: Coursework if you are taking the **Coursework route** for your IGCSE, along with Paper 1: Poetry and Prose and Paper 3: Drama (Open Book). You must do two assignments on two different texts. The guide below will enable you to approach Component 5: Coursework with confidence. It is divided into:

- Overview
- Breaking down the question
- Top tips

## Overview

The coursework is set and assessed internally by your centre and **moderated** externally by the exam board. The component as a whole is worth 25 marks and is made up of a portfolio of **two** assignments. Each assignment should be 600–1200 words in length, including quotations but excluding references and a bibliography. Each assignment must be on a different text and based on the study of a complete text. One of the assignments may be on a set text for Papers 1, 2 or 3. If poetry or short stories are used, then you must cover a minimum of two poems or short stories. You can write your assignments electronically or by hand, and you can discuss them in general terms with your teacher, but your teacher is not allowed to proofread, correct or mark your draft assignments. If your assignments are significantly over or under the word count, you may lose marks.

In your response you are expected to:

- Demonstrate your knowledge of the text through reference to detail and the use of accurate, relevant quotations
- Show that you understand the main ideas and explicit meanings in the text, as well as the implied or hidden meanings
- Analyse, in detail, the choices the writer has made in terms of their use of language, structure and form to **convey**

**Stuck on something?**

Ask questions and get help with exactly what you're revising.

Got it

- Demonstrate your understanding of the text, and the question
- Be sensitive to imagery and language to develop an informed personal response to the text

It is important to plan, re-read and check your work.

# Breaking down the question

Help me understand

For this component, your teacher should set tasks that allow you to demonstrate the skills outlined in the assessment objectives. You may be asked to write a **critical** response, in which you are asked to explore and analyse the methods an author has used to achieve certain effects, based on a theme. Alternatively, you may be asked to write an **empathic** response: this means you will be asked to imagine that you are one of the characters in a text and write your response as though you were that character at a particular moment in a prose or drama text.

It is important to note that writing a plot summary or a character sketch will not receive high marks; neither will reviews of plays or novels or poetry comparison. Successful critical essays are those that allow you to explore the ways in which writers make their characters, themes and settings memorable and vivid. Successful empathic essays should place the author's created world at the centre of the response. The best responses integrate a compellingly authentic "voice" for the chosen character and a wide range of detail based on the text.

Below are a range of examples of coursework assignment tasks:

| | |
|---|---|
| Critical tasks | In what ways does Williams powerfully convey the tensions in the relationship between Blanche and Stanley in A Streetcar Named Desire? |
| | Explore the ways in which Wordsworth uses imagery to powerful effect in two of his poems. |
| | In what ways does Dickens use setting to reflect two of the characters in Great Expectations? |
| Empathic tasks | You are Stella, alone, at the end of the play, thinking about what has happened to your sister. Write your thoughts. (Tennessee Williams, A Streetcar Named Desire) |

| | |
|---|---|
| | (William Golding, Lord of the Flies) |
| | You are Nwoye, leaving your father Okonkwo for the last time. You are walking back to the church. Write your thoughts. (Chinua Achebe, Things Fall Apart) |

# Top tips

- Make sure you write the full title at the top of each assignment
- Answer the question, making sure that every sentence adds something important to your argument
- Avoid writing irrelevant background information
- Avoid overly long introductions and conclusions:
  - Get straight to the point
  - Starting your assignment with "In this essay I shall discuss two poems..." does not receive any marks, so this kind of introduction should be avoided

- The best coursework demonstrates confidence in expressing individual views based on solid textual evidence:
  - The strongest critical essays skillfully integrate specific, relevant textual reference with precise, analytical comment
  - These essays use quotes to shine a spotlight on a particular word or phrase in order to comment on how writers achieve their effects
  - The points you make should be developed into a coherent argument

- The strongest empathic responses show detailed knowledge demonstrated by a wide range of textual references or echoes of the text:
  - They also demonstrate a well-crafted and sustained insight into the character at a specific moment
  - They assume an authentic "voice" and viewpoint for the character

- Do not just state your ideas:
  - The most convincing responses sustain a critical engagement with the ways in which writers achieve their effects
  - Therefore, it is important that your explanation and analysis is supported with reasons
  - Use words such as "because", "as" or "since" to offer reasons as to how the writer's choices of language and structure achieve the particular effects that you mention
  - Make sure you link all of your ideas and reasons to the question

- Embed your quotations into your sentences:
  - Avoid unnecessary phrases such as "This is shown by the quote…" as this is just a waste of words
  - Instead, try: "The writer creates sympathy for the character by describing her as 'small and weak'"

sympathy for the character"
    - This does not make any specific point that the examiner could reward with a mark
- Avoid being narrative:
    - You do not get any marks for just re-telling the story
- Ensure you include analysis of the use of structure and the form of the text:
    - This is especially important when considering, for example, a writer's use of dialogue
- In addition, avoid "feature-spotting":
    - Listing techniques a writer has used without analysis will not get you marks
- Your conclusion should be relevant and should summarise your personal response to the text and the task:
    - The strongest answers provide evidence of an informed and sensitive personal response to the text, which focuses directly on the key words of questions
    - It should not just repeat points you have already made

Teacher only

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